# Art of the Boom

Record-breaking auctions are fuelling a surge in demand for Indian art, but sustaining the momentum will depend on a growing collector base, stronger cultural institutions, and wider public access

BY **SAKSHI BATRA**

**ABOUT $18 MILLION.** That's ₹167.2 crore. You might think this is the price of a sprawling mansion or a luxury penthouse. Think again. This is the highest value for a Raja Ravi Varma painting—*Yashoda and Krishna*—a tender, timeless portrayal of a mother and child. When the painting went under the hammer in April 2026, it did more than set an auction record. It put a spotlight on India's growing appetite for art, where cultural icons are commanding extraordinary prices and a new generation of collectors is changing the rules of the market.

Indian art is being recognised not merely as an object of aesthetic appreciation, but as a repository of cultural legacy, personal identity, and long-term value. The country's secondary art market reported a decade-high turnover of ₹2,543 crore in 2025, more than tripling from ₹792 crore in 2015, on the back of collector participation, higher prices, and rising interest from high-net-worth domestic collectors, according to 360 ONE's The Collector's Guide 2026.

Artery India, an art market intelligence firm that tracks secondary-market auctions, puts the 2025–26 turnover above ₹2,660 crore, more than double the number four years ago. "I project a sustained annual growth of 20–25%, which would take the market to ₹7,500–8,000 crore by 2030," says founder Arvind Vijay Mohan.

For Minal Vazirani, the co-founder of auction house Saffronart, Raja Ravi Varma's *Yashoda and Krishna*, which broke the world record for the highest value painting by a South Asian artist, was a significant moment for the Indian art landscape. "It demonstrated the importance collectors place on works that combine exceptional artistic quality, historical significance and cultural resonance, and reflects a growing confidence in the Indian art market."



**"It is certainly promising to see Indian artists achieving record-breaking prices, as it reflects growing interest and confidence in the market"**

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